ARTS 1301: Art Appreciation — Critical Analysis Module

Mechanical Eyes and Machine Minds: From 19th-Century Photography to Generative AI (Assignment 2.2)

Part 1: Close Reading and Textual Analysis

1. **The Facts of Photography as an Art Process**
   - Concrete Facts & Mechanical Procedures: John Andrews details that photography is fundamentally a machine-made art relying on chemical emulsions (collodion and gelatine plates), optical lenses, shutters, actinometers, and printing processes (platinotype, autotype, etc.). The early photographic process recorded excessive, obtrusive detail—every stick, stone, and the high light in a fly's eye. Furthermore, photography suffered from a lack of true atmosphere and an inability to render the true scale of light and shade (having false local colour and false relative tone because actinic rays do not match visual rays).
   -
   - Definition and Purpose of Art: Based on these technical realities, Andrews concludes that photography can never truly replace traditional painting or become an original "fine art" in its own right; rather, it is an "art of reproduction" or a "sister art" that acts as the patient drudge to painting's original genius. The true purpose of fine art is poetry—seeing nature through an ideal light that never was on sea and shore—whereas photography must content itself largely with the "light of common day".
   -

2. **The Character of the True Artist**
   - Artist vs. Routine Machine Operator: Andrews argues that what separates a true artist from a mere machine operator is "artistic feeling" and education. While anyone can operate the mechanical apparatus, an artist brings individual genius, selection, composition, and emotional interpretation.
   -
   - To 'Wait and Watch': When Andrews asserts that the photographer must "learn to watch and wait" (p. 7), he signifies deep intentionality and patience. Nature does not present herself ready-composed; the true artist-photographer must study the lighting, anticipate passing atmospheric effects (such as twilight, mist, or sweeping cloud shadows), and deliberately choose *when* and *what* to capture, treating failures as stepping stones rather than taking indiscriminate "pot shots".
   -

3. Photography in Service of the Arts

- Mutual Assistance: In Chapter 2, Andrews outlines how photography serves traditional fine arts without supplanting them. Photography provides artists with exact records of plain facts, details of rocks, trees, skies, animals in motion, and architecture that would take hours to sketch. It also preserves perishable works (old manuscripts, coins, sculpture) through reproduction processes like heliogravure and autotype.
-
- Proper Subordinate Use: Painters should use photographs as a supplemental reference to study natural details or proportions (such as building heights), but *never* as a substitute for direct labor, outdoor study, and imaginative composition. The moment an artist relies entirely on a photograph without personal vision, the work becomes stiff and theatrical (resembling "signpost paintings").
-

Part 2: Critical Quote Analysis

Quote 1 (Page 8)

"After all, it is a question of artistic feeling, and it is a great mistake to suppose that without this you can produce artistic work." — John Andrews, Studies in Photography, 1892

1. Constituents of 'Artistic Feeling': In Andrews's framework, "artistic feeling" refers to an educated aesthetic sensibility, an innate appreciation for poetry and harmony, and a deep familiarity with the works of great masters (such as Turner, Constable, and Corot). It is the internal vision that guides selection, composition, and mood.
2.
3. Transforming Mechanical Routine: Mechanical tools alone produce sterile, over-detailed records. Artistic feeling transforms this routine by imposing human choice—deciding what to omit, how to soften obtrusive details through focus or atmospheric conditions, and how to infuse a monotint image with emotional expression and repose.
4.

Quote 2 (Page 12)

"Emerson has well expressed it when he defined art as 'Nature passed through the alembic of man.'" — Cited by John Andrews, p. 12

1. The Alembic Metaphor: An alembic is a traditional chemical vessel used for distillation and purification. Emerson and Andrews use this metaphor to argue that raw nature cannot become art simply by being copied. Instead, nature's raw inputs must be boiled down, filtered, and transmuted through human consciousness, intellect, and imagination.
2.
3. Intellectual and Emotional Transformation: Within the "alembic of man," raw optical data is stripped of vulgar literalism and infused with human emotion, memory, spiritual aspiration, and stylistic unity. The resulting artwork is not a mirror image of the physical world, but a purified essence reflecting the human soul.

4.

Quote 3 (Page 12)

"Photography is a most useful and curious invention and of the greatest value for the record of plain facts about persons and places, but it is not a fine art at all and can never be made one."
— Philip Gilbert Hamerton, cited by John Andrews, p. 12

1. Hamerton's Critique: Hamerton asserts this because photography operates mechanically via optics and chemistry rather than human hand-craft and imaginative invention. Because the camera records every trivial detail indiscriminately ("tells us too much") and lacks the ability to execute true tonal subdivision and color translation, it remains bound to literal fact.
2.
3. Threshold of 'Fine Art': To cross into fine art under Hamerton's criteria, a medium must possess the capacity for deliberate selection, idealization, emotional emphasis, and manual interpretation—qualities he believed were impossible for a machine lens.
4.
5. Hamerton vs. Emerson: Hamerton's view suggests that photographic technology bypasses human distillation entirely, acting as a passive mirror of external reality. In contrast, Emerson's alembic requires active human agency. Andrews attempts to bridge these views by arguing that while early photography was purely mechanical, a photographer gifted with "artistic feeling" can intervene through lighting, focus, and chemistry to pass nature through human consciousness.
6.

Part 3: The Family of the Arts and the Contemporary AI Controversy

1. The Kinship of Media and Generative AI

- Digital Art vs. Traditional Painting: Digital art (painting via stylus and tablet) operates comfortably within the family of fine arts as a modern cousin to traditional painting. It retains direct human hand-eye coordination, intent, and manual mark-making.
-
- Generative AI's Lineage: Generative AI (*Théâtre D'opéra Spatial* via Midjourney) occupies an entirely different technological and philosophical category. Unlike photography—which Andrews classified as a mechanical reproduction of existing optical reality—generative AI is an algorithmic synthesizer operating on statistical pattern recognition derived from scraped human datasets.
-
- Applying Historical Frameworks:
-

    - Under Hamerton's rigorous criteria, AI text-to-image generation fails even faster than 19th-century photography because the human operator does not even

manipulate optics or chemistry; they merely type a text prompt, abdicating both mechanical execution and physical presence.

- Under Emerson's and Andrews's more flexible views, an AI artist could theoretically be seen as a director or curator who uses prompts and iterative curation as a modern "alembic." However, Andrews would likely caution that because the algorithm performs the actual synthesis, the human creator risks losing the intimate, bodily communion with nature and material that defines authentic artistic feeling.

2. Evaluating the Colorado State Fair Verdict (*Théâtre D'opéra Spatial*)

- Fairness of Jason M. Allen's Victory: Winning a digital art award with an AI-generated piece sparked intense debate because it blurred the line between human creation and machine generation.
- Critique via Hamerton: If we align with Hamerton, Allen's victory was deeply unfair to human digital artists. Typing a text prompt into Midjourney is an act of commissioning or directing, not artistic execution. It bypasses the foundational struggle of form, perspective, and brushwork.
- Defense via Andrews / Emerson: Conversely, if we align with a progressive interpretation of Andrews and Emerson, Allen engaged in advanced curation, prompt engineering, aesthetic selection, and iterative refinement. Just as a photographer selects the right lighting and shutter speed, an AI artist selects the most evocative latent space outputs among hundreds of variations, passing digital noise through human taste and intent.
- Conclusion & Reasoned Assessment: Ultimately, generative AI represents a hybrid paradigm: it is fundamentally an automated collation of statistical patterns, but it can be steered by human intent. While it should not be categorized as traditional fine art due to the absence of direct human craftsmanship, it constitutes a new form of *algorithmic direction*. To honor both human artistry and technological innovation, art competitions must establish distinct categories for AI-assisted works rather than pitting algorithms directly against human-crafted brushwork and digital painting.